MIDDLEMARCH by George Eliot
(B1+–B2+)

INTRODUCTION

Ss read an extract from *Middlemarch* by George Eliot in which Dorothea's husband makes a strange request of her before he dies. Then they listen to an extract continuing the story in which Dorothea finds out exactly what her husband's will entails. Ss learn about unusual wills and find out about authors who write under pen names.

Supplementary Materials

WARM UP: a sealed envelope with a note inside saying 'Do extra homework tonight.' Or some other light-hearted task that most people would not want to do.

ACTIVE INVESTIGATION: internet access

CLIL CONNECTION: internet access

Culture notes

George Eliot

Mary Anne Evans, better known by her pen name George Eliot, is thought to be one of the best Victorian writers. Her books generally deal with social change and its effect on society as well as matters of the heart. She offers the reader an in-depth and realistic view of English provincial life in the 19th century, describing the behaviour and attitudes of the different classes and revealing the hypocrisy with which they often led their lives. Many of her books are still in print today and some have been adapted to film.

Middlemarch

Middlemarch takes the theme of the lives of the various social classes and tells it through two main stories: one of which is that of Dorothea and her disastrous marriage to the older Mr Casaubon. Dorothea marries in the hopes of supporting her husband in his life's work, a book, but he only wants her as a secretary and she begins to doubt that his work has any real merit. When he dies, he makes a provision in his will that if she marries his cousin, Will Ladislaw, she will inherit nothing. At first, she tries to comply with this request but later marries Will and gives up the money and house for love and happiness.

WARM UP

Hold up the envelope (see Supplementary materials) and tell Ss that there is a command or instruction inside. Offer it to one student at random and say they can open it but only if they agree to do whatever it says inside. They will probably refuse, if they're sensible, since they don't know what it says! Offer a few more Ss and then ask why they don't want to do it. (Presumably because they don't know what they're agreeing to.) If someone agrees, ask *Don't you want to know what it says first?* If someone does still accept, let them open the envelope. If no-one accepts, open the envelope and show them the instruction you've written and make out they have had a wise escape. Tell them they're going to come across this idea (of agreeing to unknown requests) during the lesson.

PREPARATION

THINKING ROUTINE

1

see

Focus Ss on the picture of the confetti. Ask *What life event do you associate with this picture?* (marriage, a wedding)

think, wonder

Focus Ss on the questions and allow time for them to discuss in pairs. Monitor and help with vocabulary as needed. Make a note of anything useful on the board to go over at feedback. In feedback, elicit Ss' ideas as a whole class but there are no right ideas, only Ss' perhaps differing opinions. Note on the board the range of answers for Question 3.

COMPREHENSION

READING PREVIEW

Focus Ss on the title and ask *Why is the request a 'last' request?* (Because the person making it is asking for what they want after they die.) Introduce the word 'will' and the concept if Ss are not familiar with it (a letter in which you write instructions for your belongings and money after your death). Ask *What kinds of things do people ask in their will?* Elicit general ideas.

READING EXTRACT LL10.01

Tell Ss they are going to read an extract from *Middlemarch* about a conversation between a husband and wife. Allow time for them to read in silence, or play the recording while they read.

When they have finished, ask *What do you think Mr Casaubon was planning to ask her to do?* Explain, if Ss need it, that he asked her if she would obey his wishes in his will after he died, and he wanted her to agree without knowing what he had written in his will. So, they are trying to guess the will's request (not the request for her to obey him).

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Write on the board, or ask:

- *Was Dorothea happily married to Mr Casaubon?* (No) Get Ss to note all the things that make them think that. (She feels her life will be helping him with work of no importance; she seems to dread the idea of fifteen more years with him; the thought of the future makes her feel ill and helpless and unable to sleep; she describes her future as a living hell; she can't eat.)
- *Why did she decide to promise to obey the request in his will?* (Duty to her husband as a wife but Ss may have other ideas as this is not explicitly stated.) *Why did he ask her this?* (To control her, also perhaps he felt that he was about to die.)
- *How do you think she feels that he dies?* (Ss own interpretations but they themselves might think she would be relieved, maybe even happy.)

2 **Focus Ss on the summary, but ask them to cover the words in the box at first. Tell them to read the summary and ask about any words they don't know, ignoring the gaps for now. Then ask them to read the summary again, this time, if they find that any answers pop into their heads for the gap fill, to make a note of them. Then refer them to the words in the box to see if any of the words they noted match the words in the box. Then they try and put the rest of the words into the remaining gaps.**

ANSWERS:

1 wishes **2** marriage **3** value **4** refuse **5** garden

LISTENING

3 LL10.02 **Focus on the words in the glossary so Ss will recognise them when they hear them. Explain that what they are about to listen to is later in the story, when Dorothea reads her husband's will. Ss listen once or twice as needed and confirm the predictions they made after the reading. After they have got the answer, ask what they think of Mr Casaubon's request. (They may think it acceptable or unacceptable.)**

ANSWERS:

That she will inherit nothing if she marries Will Ladislaw.

LL10.02 AUDIOSCRIPT

After a week of sitting sadly, she felt ready to look through her husband's papers for his **will**.

Her eyes ran over the document. He had left their house, Lowick Manor, and its land to her as expected, but then her blood ran cold. He had recently added a sentence at the bottom. As she read his **spidery** writing, a knife seemed to **twist** in her heart: 'If Dorothea ever marries Mr Will Ladislaw, she must leave Lowick Manor immediately. She will lose the house, the land and the income.'

ACTIVE INVESTIGATION

4A **Tell Ss that using a will to take revenge on family or to try to control them also happens in real life. People also make unusual requests in their wills. See if Ss have any stories of strange will requests that they know of, or have heard about.**

Then divide them into pairs and allow time for them to research the requests in Questions 1–4. They can use the internet, either at home or in class. Check answers as a class. Ask *Whose request was the strangest? Whose was the most unfair?*

ANSWERS:

1 Henry Budd left £200,000 fortune to his two sons as long as 'neither sullied his lip with a moustache'.

2 Frederick Baur, the inventor of the Pringle tube, wanted his ashes buried in one of the tubes. (His family chose the Original flavour.)

3 Wellington Burt asked that no-one could inherit his millions until 21 years after all his children and grandchildren had died. So, 21 years after the last of their deaths, in 2010, 12 people shared his 'legacy of bitterness', worth about $110m.

4 Marvel Comics editor and writer (Captain America), Mark Gruenwald, asked for his ashes to be mixed into the ink used in the first trade paperback anthology of his Squadron Supreme.

B **Remind Ss that there was an age difference between Dorothea and her husband. Ask them to research to find out what the age difference was. They will probably need to use the internet for this. Check the answer as a class.**

ANSWERS:

19 and about 44 as different sources give different ages from 45–47, or 'almost fifty' but he is 25 years her senior so anything from 44 is correct.

SPEAKING

5 **Focus Ss on the questions and allow time for them to discuss in pairs. NB They have already thought about how Dorothea felt about her marriage but now they can also think how her husband felt about it. Encourage them to think whether or not Mr Casaubon sensed that his young wife was not happy and how that might have influenced him.**

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ANSWERS:

Ss' own answers but we can suppose Dorothea was disappointed and her husband insecure and suspicious otherwise he wouldn't have put the clause in his will preventing her from marrying Will Ladislaw. We can also suppose Will is younger, a friend of Dorothea's and more her age and that her husband thought she had been unfaithful. In fact, in the book this is what the will made people think.

CLIL CONNECTION

Literature

6 **Ask *Who was the author of Middlemarch?* (George Eliot) Ss may need to look at the front cover of the Pearson English Reader on page 164. Then ask *Was the author a man or woman?* (A woman) Do not confirm the answer at this stage but tell them they're going to find out more about the author.**

Focus Ss on Questions 1–2 and allow time for them to research the answers online, either at home or in class. Feedback and check answers as a class.

Ask *Do you know any other writers who use pen names?* Elicit answers. Then focus on Question 3 and allow time to research before checking answers as a class.

ANSWERS:

Mary Ann Evans

1 It's surprising that she's a woman since George is a man's name.

2 She didn't want her books dismissed as silly romance novels because she was a woman which must have been a prejudice of the era. It still has some relevance today as female writers sometimes use pen names or just initials in some genres in order to be taken more seriously. Also, she was already known under her own name as an editor and critic and may have wanted to keep her fiction separate. Some people believe she wanted less focus on her private life.

3 a) Robert Galbraith. She wanted to write a completely different kind of book (*The Cuckoo's Calling*; crime novel) from *Harry Potter* and used a pen name to take the pressure off. Sales improved dramatically when the truth was revealed. It first came to light via an anonymous tip off but it was confirmed by computer analysis of the linguistic style of the writing.

b) Richard Bachman. His publishers thought it wasn't a good idea for a writer to publish more than one book per year in case people got bored, so he published under a pen name but he also wanted to see if his books would sell on their own merit and not just because his name was so famous. A bookshop worker noticed similarities in the writing style and investigated publishing documents at the public library which recorded the true writer's name.

c) Paul French. Although he was already writing science-fiction, when he was asked to write one for teens to be made into a TV series, he decided to use a pen name as he thought the television shows of the time were 'uniformly awful'. In the end, the TV programme idea was dropped but he wrote more books for the *Lucky Starr* series. He wrote as Paul French but included heavy clues to his real identity as he no longer had to worry about being associated with a TV programme.

Homework idea

Ss choose a famous person, alive or dead, and write a will for them.

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